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THE WAVE PM Modi with K. Annamalai (right) and Union minister L. Murugan at a roadshow in Coimbatore, Mar. 18

AFTER THE MAY 2021 LOSS, THE AIADMK REALISED ITS TIES WITH THE BJP WERE JEOPARDISING ITS DRAVIDIAN IDENTITY. THEY BROKE UP IN SEPTEMBER 2023

the heavy lifting (he has visited the state at least 10 times in the past 6-7 months). The *sengol* display as a symbol of Tamil pride at the inaugural of the new Parliament building, the announcement of projects worth over Rs 30,000 crore for the state (most of which the PM himself inaugurated), the regular Kashi-Tamil Sangamam programmes in Varanasi, the 'En Mann, En Makkal (My Soil, My People)' yatra by state BJP chief K. Annamalai that covered all 234 assembly constituencies, have all helped raise the party's profile. The PM's latest gambit has been raking up the Katchatheevu issue and portraying it as an abject surrender by the Congress-ruled Centre in Delhi in collusion with the DMK in Chennai 50 years ago. It's an emotive issue, especially in the southern Tamil Nadu coastal region.

The game plan is to break the 57-year-old duopoly of the Dravidian majors in 2026. In his speeches, Modi repeatedly berates the DMK over its 'misrule' in the past three years, its dynastic politics and its anti-Hindu leanings without overdoing the Ayodhya Ram mandir consecration (it has not had much resonance in the state). The goal, for now, is to get the vote share to double digits (a distinct possibility for it had scored close to 6 per cent in the 2022 local polls) and, hopefully, win 1-2 seats. The constituency focus is on Coimbatore, Nilgiris, Ramanathapuram, Kanyakumari, Tirunelveli and seats in and around Chennai.

Younger by the Day

In a state where 80 per cent of the voters are under 50, all parties have fielded candidates with an eye on that factor—together, the DMK, AIADMK, Congress, BJP, PMK, DMDK and NTK have fielded 78 candidates under 50.

The DMK has gone in for a mix of fresh faces and political heavyweights, with 11 new names among its 21 contestants. The BJP has done one better, launching 12 new faces in its 19 seats, while the AIADMK has an almost virgin crew, 30 newbies among its 32 candidates.

The DMK has also taken care not to ruffle caste equations, fielding nominees from communities dominant in their respective areas. It has picked candidates from the Vanniyar community in the north, Mukkulathor in the delta and southern districts, while going for Kongu Vellalar (or Gounder) candidates in western Tamil Nadu.

With Vanniyar-centric PMK fielding its candidates in most seats in north Tamil Nadu in the BJP alliance, the DMK has taken steps to blunt their chances. It has fielded Vanniyar nominees of its own in Arakkonam, Vellore, Dharmapuri, Arani and Salem in the north. With most of the top AIADMK leaders being Gounders, the DMK, too, has picked candidates from the community for the three seats in the west—Coimbatore, Pollachi and Erode—it is contesting. In the delta region, the party has chosen a Mukkulathor. It has fewer candidates from the community as most of the seats in the south, where their numbers are strong, have gone to the allies.

Stalin is leaving little to chance in what he calls the "final fight against fascism". So, what lends the DMK its distinct edge? "Core ideological strength and Stalin's strong leadership have been vital in the DMK's revival. A crucial factor in the SPA's success is the trust in the reliability of vote transfer to ensure the victory of allies," says political analyst Ramu Manivannan. Social commentator N. Sathiya Moorthy adds, "The choice of constituencies, the firmness with which Stalin has dealt with allies